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Philosophy of Mind

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A Mutant Puzzle

Often, art is prized for being original, creative, imaginative, or any other word that conveys newness in some way. I believe this may be the sort of prize I should never receive. While it may sound self-deprecating to those who believe they are deeply imaginative and creative, I say I have no imagination with no negative connotation. By imagination, I mean the ability to conjure up or create new images, and by both imagination and creativity, I mean the ability for my mind to create something new. I do not think I am entirely incapable of creating new things – my body has provided the faculties to produce my voice, presumably a sound created by my unique voice box and physical body. Mentally, no image I “see” in my head or draw on the page or idea I think or put to paper is new. I am in no way asserting that imagination and creativity do not exist; to do so would be to deny every person in history who did something that had never been done before. But, if, say, every pioneer in history were to read this paper and decide they too didn’t have an imagination or creativity, then maybe I’d be inclined to say they don’t. Ultimately, it is not for me to judge how others’ minds work, so instead I judge my own.

One might ask, what entails newness? In this paper, when I say something is new, I mean that, before its creation, no part of it had existed in the minds of others. I see imagination and creativity as the factories by which newness is produced. I will discuss how these factories can cease to exist in one's mind and how that mind can make the same things an imaginative person may deem new. In this discussion, I will selfishly offer an alternative for the word “new”, so that the imaginativeless, namely I, can more fairly characterize their constructions (I

intentionally use construction here to avoid using “creation” but am not certain of the suitability of it over words like innovation, invention, formation, etc.).

Instead of calling them the imaginativeless, since that’s a mouthful, I’d like to use the word artist. Artists, in the normal sense of the word, are often labeled as creators of art. Unless that artist is accused of derivativeness or art theft, much of their work is labeled “new”. The artist, in my sense of the word, is a collage artist, likely in multiple facets of their life. For a moment, let’s pretend every mental and physical image, idea, concept, or thing can be transformed into a jigsaw puzzle. This puzzle consists of infinitely small puzzle pieces that make up the whole (pretend for this thought experiment that every puzzle has different content but the same jigsaw pattern so any piece of any puzzle could attach to the piece of another). The individual pieces of this puzzle are materials with which the artist collages. The collage artist can both take a single puzzle and put it together the “wrong” way, and put together pieces from multiple puzzles. Both options create what I will call a mutant puzzle. If we seal all the cracks between the pieces of these seemingly poorly put-together new puzzles, we have made something other than the original puzzles, but is it new? I’d argue no. In the same way, I can imagine two foods that taste the same yet have different ingredients, or in the way that two photo mosaics that create the same overall image can have drastically different minuscule photos constituting it, I can conceive of two identical-looking mutant puzzles that were made from non-identical jigsaw pieces. Maybe the collage artist is unaware of this identical mutant puzzle, or maybe it doesn’t exist yet, but nonetheless, the collage artist conceives of the possibility of its existence, therefore eradicating the collage artist’s own mutant puzzle of its newness. Instead, the collage artist, if making something that the “creatives” deem new, finds their puzzle, or collage,

locally unique - different than anything they are experientially certain exists, but not new. In this sense, local means contextual or experiential.

To further clarify this idea of local uniqueness, think of an art gallery that puts on one exhibit at a time. The first exhibit at this gallery displays all of the pieces of your mutant puzzle. Pretend that every day the puzzle exhibited in this gallery is replaced with a different puzzle, the only rule being that puzzles are identical mutant puzzles (think back to the idea of an identical mutant puzzle with non-identical parts). If I were to attend this gallery every day, I would have a unique experience in which I encountered different puzzle pieces with every distinct exhibit. But, I wouldn't claim I was attending a new gallery each day. It would be a little bit more accurate to say that I saw new puzzle pieces. But the exhibition's artist, a collage artist, would then correct you: every puzzle piece in the exhibit is itself a mutant puzzle and therefore, not new. Recurse down this mutant puzzle chain until we reach the level where the puzzles are concepts or physical objects or experiences or universal truths or whatever unit makes most sense to you to indicate that these puzzles are no longer mutant. At this base case exists the collage artist's first set of materials or puzzles. Maybe their first collage was their first word, drawing, or thought. Unfortunately, I will not further explore what this first set of puzzles is or what they have the potential to make, but I do believe in their existence.

If the mutant puzzle piece gallery doesn't make a shred of sense to you, you may be what I previously referred to as a "creative" (which I meant to mean those who truly believe in the newness of their creations and imaginations). If you resonate with the identity of the collage artist I've been speaking of, you may at this point ask me, how did you come to realize you were a collage artist?

It started with a study of culture. Anthropologists like Sapir and Benedict emphasize understanding culture as the totality of a person's learned, accumulated, and socially transmitted experiences. I was convinced of the importance of understanding the cultural context to understand the individual in a culture, extrapolating the idea that every person is the sum of their experiences. The part of Sapir's argument that puzzled me was the resistance to abstracting any part of a culture to understand it. While the cultural context is immensely important in saying a culture's parts were inextricable from the whole, it made anthropology seem like an impossible study. I cannot understand a culture's parts without understanding the cultural context, and I cannot grasp the cultural context without intimately knowing its parts. The anthropologist seemed to agree that there are many jigsaw pieces, or experiences, that, when held together, form a puzzle, or the cultural context. But if you pick a single piece of the puzzle off, it melts into a little puddle in the palm of your hand. How then did the puzzle pieces ever form?

This question was tucked away in my mind as I flipped through the pages of a book of artwork by painter Remedios Varo. Her artworks are seemingly magical, surreal, and rooted in science fiction and invention. At the time, I thought, "she may be the most imaginative painter... ever". I stared at a painting of a creature crafting a songbird at a workbench by wielding a string from their violin heart while reflecting color and light off of the moon through the prism they held in one hand. The material alchemist shown had human feet, white baggy sleeves, and an owl head and body. I had never seen anything like it before. I believed I was seeing something new - something no one had ever conjured up before. Remedios Varo has no writings explaining her paintings, leaving me staring at this painting, wondering if any of my associations were even close to true. Even in all my awe and wonderment, I couldn't help but look at its parts and wonder how those parts had been chosen or if they had been chosen at all. Maybe what I saw as

an owl was a new creature Remedios Varo had created herself. While I was unable to label her artwork as a whole as anything other than unexplainably unique, the parts seemed to refer to ideas and things more basic than the whole. It's hard for me to conceive that Remedios Varo was not thinking of owls and alchemists and surgeons when painting this piece of work, or that those things were not images she found personally impactful in her lifetime, but I will not let my lack of conception prohibit the possibility that her artwork was completely imaginatively created to her. What my experience of viewing this artwork gave me was my reflex to dissect the whole into its parts. I could not conceive of this image being imagined or created without a mountain of sources, and for each of those sources to not have their own derivative source, a source based on another source. I can now conceive of a way to explain or examine the parts of a whole, something anthropology did not offer me.

So I revisited my question. How did the puzzle pieces form? Well if something like culture is created by accumulation of experience, and the individual parts of an image have a recursive chain of derivative sources, and if I pretend for a second that my hypothetical puzzle is somewhat like a real jigsaw puzzle that creates an image, then maybe each puzzle piece, or experience in the case of the cultural context, is derived from a chain of derivative sources. In the context of imagination, I become a collage artist where every derivative source is a mutant puzzle. But where else does this chain of reasoning apply in my life? If I believe this about my imagination, what else must I believe about myself?

One area where I find the answer to this question is the problem of free will. The problem of free will asks if we have genuine freedom of choice in our lives, or if all of our choices are the result of a previous choice and therefore determined for us. This causal chain greatly mimics the

chain of derivative sources we have just discussed, but let's see if there is more nuance to the problem of free will for a collage artist.

To map the mutant puzzle thought experiment onto the problem of free will, the question of whether or not our choices are genuinely free replaces the question of newness. Our will or a choice is represented by a mutant puzzle/collage. An identical mutant puzzle with non-identical parts would represent the making of the same choice if you had a different life experience previously. It seems that our question was answered as soon as we replaced newness with freedom. The collage artist does not think that their mutant puzzle is new so it follows that the collage artist does not think that their choices are completely free.

But there are less straightforward conclusions when we consider that we have mapped the idea of two identical mutant puzzles incorrectly to two choices that come from different life experiences. Alternatively, an identical mutant puzzle could represent a different person who made the same choice as you. But, if all choices and outcomes are determined by your previous choice and its outcomes, then this would present the idea that two people who made exactly the same choices their entire lives could have entirely different content that makes up their being. If this is the correct interpretation, then it seems that the answer to the free will problem for a collage artist is that their choices are determined, but their self, identity, experiences, etc, are dependent on something else that I am entirely unsure of: environment, soul, genetics, god?

Let's now entertain the first interpretation of the identical mutant puzzle. If a singular person could be conceived to have had multiple life experiences with the same predetermined choices, then I'm inclined to say that while the collage artist's choices are determined, the content of their being is not. This seems to trivialize the problem of free will – why should we

care about our will if it has no bearing on who we are as people? If our choices don't alter our experience, then what does? I'm not sure I can answer this question.

In the case of imagination, I introduced this notion of local uniqueness, so it may not be fair to close this case by saying that a collage artist believes everything about themselves is determined. Let's try to find a similar alternative to genuine freedom. Just as the collage artist can make locally unique puzzles, where the manipulation of and process of making each mutant puzzle is potentially distinct, it's plausible that the collage artist can have local autonomy or freedom in how we arrange the choices we make to form and mold our experiences. We saw that there was some disconnect between our choices and experiences, so it seems fair to say that it is the way we choose to incorporate the decisions and their outcomes in our lives that dictates our experience. Our response to our choices is how we exercise our local autonomy. I'll offer a visualization I find helpful in conceptualizing local autonomy: the freedom we have to handle and navigate the choices we make is like a collage artist simply spinning or changing the orientation of a mutant puzzle before a new puzzle piece can be added. The internal connections of the previous choices are preserved, but the way in which the next decision will be made will be added in a slightly different perspective and color.

Up until now, I have worked under the assumption that, in the free will case, once a choice is made, it is unchangeable – there is only one puzzle for your choices, and it can only have parts added to it, not taken. Given my personal discomfort with the determinism discussed thus far, I'd like to see what becomes of the free will problem when we allow choices, not to be taken back, but to be revisited; what if not every choice impacted every other choice, but mutant puzzles were created on a case-by-case basis by combining select mutant puzzles. In other words, because every mutant puzzle has only parts of every choice made before it, every new

choice is not determined by the full weight of every choice the artist has ever made. This interpretation is actually more faithful to the original thought experiment and implies that the local autonomy that we discussed earlier may mean we have the freedom to consider to what extent certain past choices should play a part in our next decision, which is essentially the process of making a new mutant puzzle. In this case, the histories of your puzzles remain connected, but the collage artist has the power to greatly influence the weight, power, or quantity of puzzle pieces from the archive of mutant puzzles that represent your past choices.

Having only recently explored the implications of my collaging tendencies on my understanding of free will, I hope my third interpretation is the right one. It's the one I can most conceive I have been partaking in my whole life, and it gives me hope that my efforts to change myself do not face off too harshly with my growing arsenal of choices and experiences. It's still unclear to me what exactly constitutes a choice and what parts of life are not choices. I begin to ponder less philosophical and more logistical questions about how and when I am exercising my local autonomy. While it may very quickly turn into worry, I'm inclined to sit in the comfort and love I feel from collaging. The common suggestion to "work with what you have" seems less scary when you stop to think about just how big the collage you've been making is.

